

The DHS hiring surge in ICE & CBP: how big, did it stick, who's leaving?

Analyst memo · data through May 2026 · every figure is reproduced in `dhs_hiring_surge.ipynb`

Bottom line. The 2025 DHS surge was overwhelmingly an **ICE** event, concentrated in **Sept 2025–Jan 2026** and in **entry immigration-enforcement officer jobs**. It did put people on the payroll — ICE grew about 46% — and headcount has since slipped modestly (about 4% off its January peak) as those hires begin to leave. About **one in four surge hires has already left** — mostly by quitting — before their first year is even up, already past what comparable CBP law-enforcement classes shed over a *full* year (~10–11%).

Source. OPM/EHRI records for hires, departures, and monthly headcount, read directly from the Hugging-Face dataset `impactproject/opm-ehri-data`. ICE = agency code HSBG, CBP = HSD. Each record is a *count of people*, not one named individual — see caveats.

1. The surge was ICE, and it was big but brief · *notebook §1*

ICE normally hires about 700–1,300 people a year. In **2025 it hired 10,322** — roughly **8× normal** — and the burst was tightly concentrated: about **9,970 hires fell in the five months Sept 2025–Jan 2026** alone, peaking in December, then falling back to normal monthly levels. It is about 99.6% genuine new hires, **not** transfers from other agencies (transfers = 0.4%). **CBP's increase was modest** (2025 was about 1.2× its baseline); its ramp is smaller, later, and Border-Patrol-focused.

1b. The biggest hiring year in ICE's history · *notebook §1b*

Extending the series back to 2006, ICE's previous *annual* hiring record was about **1,966 (2009)**; 2025's 10,322 is about **5× ICE's all-time record and 8× its recent norm**. The **2017 executive order directing 10,000 new ICE officers produced no visible surge** — hiring stayed at about 700–1,300/year. The only comparable buildup in this data is **CBP in 2007–2009** (about 7,000–9,000 hires/year, the Bush-era Border Patrol expansion); such rapid buildups have historically lost a quarter or more of new hires early (§4b).

2. It reached the payroll — then edged down · *notebook §2*

ICE headcount went from **20,848 (Aug 2025) to 30,461 (Jan 2026)**, a roughly 46% jump. It has since **slipped to 29,219 (May 2026), down 1,242 (–4%) from the peak**, even though some hiring continued. CBP rose gradually (63k to 69k) with no reversal. So the ICE workforce is still far above its pre-surge level — up roughly 8,400 since August even after the slip — but the ~4% decline from January's peak is real, and §§3–4 show it is the surge hires themselves leaving.

3. Who the surge hires are — a job profile · *notebook §3*

With no person IDs, we identify the surge hires by the **jobs they were hired into**, comparing them with normal ICE hiring. The surge is unmistakable in job and pay plan: **job series 1801** (*General Inspection, Investigation, Enforcement, and Compliance* — the ICE deportation / immigration-enforcement officer series) is about 64% of surge hires vs 20% normally (**3.2× as common**); with **1811** (*Criminal Investigation*) the two are about 87%. **About 68% are on the GL entry law-enforcement pay plan** at grades **GL-05/07/09**. Other markers: term (non-permanent) appointments are about 3× as common, and the age mix skews unusually **older**. Profile = **GL pay plan + series 1801/1811**. Because ICE had almost no one in these jobs before the surge, any jump in departures from them *is* the surge hires.

4. The leavers are the surge hires — and they're quitting, not being let go · *notebook §4*

Departures from these jobs ran a flat **27–46 per year (2018–2024)**, then jumped to **730 (2025)** and **1,058 in the first five months of 2026** — about 50–60× the prior norm, beginning the same month hiring did. Of those exits, about **71% are voluntary quits** and **about 26% are involuntary terminations** (expired term appointments plus some probationary removals; the data lumps the two together).

4b. About one in four is already gone — before the first year is up · *notebook §4b*

Watching the whole group's exits against its own hires, **1,733 of 7,033 surge hires (24.6%) had left by May 2026** — within their first year, and still climbing because hiring stopped while exits continue. We can't yet state an ICE *first-year* rate: the group's first year isn't over (these hires are only a few months in), and annualizing a partial year would mislead. But that ~25%, reached before the first year is up, already exceeds what CBP's comparable entry classes shed over a **full** first year — about **10–11%** for **Border Patrol (series 1896-GL, Border Patrol Enforcement)** and **CBP Officer (series 1895, Customs and Border Protection)** in 2023–24 — and is closing on the roughly **29%** that CBP's own **2019–21** rapid-hire Border Patrol classes lost across a full year. ICE's early loss is already near the high end of that range, with its first year not yet complete.

What the data can't say (caveats) · *notebook §5, checked in §0*

- **Counts, not people.** We match *departing* jobs to *hiring* jobs; we can't prove a specific leaver was a specific fall-2025 hire. The match is tight only because these GL entry jobs were nearly empty before the surge (~900 people). The group we track cleanly is the ~68% who are entry law-enforcement officers (GL-1801/1811); the higher-grade officers and attorneys can't be isolated the same way.
- **Length of service ≠ time in the job.** The service figure is *total federal service*; about 30% of 2025 ICE new hires arrived with 3+ years of prior service — a mix of veterans (military credit) and prior federal civilians (rehires), **not transfers**. This is why we define the group by job and grade, not by length of service.
- **Headcount and flow don't reconcile** — hires minus departures lags the headcount change by about 15–20% (timing plus provisional late reporting), so we use headcount for *levels* and departures for *exits*, never chained. The “headcount is declining” finding rests on complete point-in-time headcount snapshots, not on provisional flows.
- **Involuntary exits can't be fully split** (term-appointment expiration vs. removal for cause), and the elevated departures are **not** a buyout-program artifact: the separations `drp_indicator` field flags **none** of the 1,733 cohort departures (and none of the ~3,450 ICE departures in the window) as deferred-resignation-program exits.

Method checked (notebook §0): ICE=HSBB / CBP=HSBD confirmed as the only ICE/CBP codes, stable 2008–2026; monthly files confirmed to *add* new actions, so summing across files and grouping by the effective-date field is required (a single file holds only ~30% of December's hires, so one-file-per-month undercounts that surge month by ~70%) and does not double-count; redaction preserves totals; headcount de-duplicated to one snapshot per file.

Reproduce: python src/extract.py and python src/history.py (pull the data to data/), then run dhs_hiring_surge.ipynb. The surge-hire definition and windows are in src/surge.py.